



Elvis Presley, seen here singing to an adoring young crowd, joined the US Army and set sail for Germany, putting a temporary halt to his extraordinary career.

MAO ZEDONG, FOUNDER OF THE PEOPLE'S REPUBLIC OF CHINA, initiated a program of reform in 1958 that would ultimately kill millions. The "**Great Leap Forward**" was intended to rapidly industrialize China's rural economy. However, Mao's scheme plunged the country into one of the worst famines in history. At least 35 million people were worked, starved, or beaten to death in the following four years.

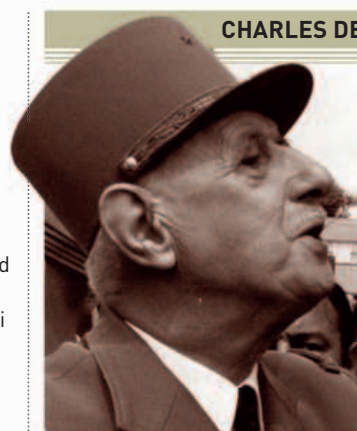
Great Leap Forward

This propaganda poster urges workers to make more steel as part of Mao Zedong's "Great Leap Forward," an attempt to modernize China.

35 MILLION THE NUMBER OF DEATHS IN THE GREAT LEAP FORWARD

The **Middle East** felt the repercussions of the **Suez Canal crisis** this year (see 1956). In February, Egypt and Syria merged

to form the **United Arab Republic**. Pro-Western regimes in the Middle East saw the union as a threat to their security, and Iraq and Jordan formed a loose union. In July, a **civil war** broke out in Lebanon between the predominantly Christian and strongly pro-Western regime of **President Camille Chamoun** and the **Muslim Socialist National Front**. On July 14, a group of Iraqi Free Officers led by Brigadier Abdul Karim Qasim captured power in Baghdad in a savage **military coup**. King Faisal II, the regent Abdul Illah, and Prime Minister Nuri al-Said were murdered.



CHARLES DE GAULLE (1890–1970)

A soldier, politician, and statesman, Charles de Gaulle became head of the provisional government of France in 1944. Elected president in 1945, he resigned in 1946, returning to power in 1958 to solve the crisis brought about by the Algerian War. He resigned again in 1969 after being defeated in a referendum on constitutional reform.

The Iraqi coup threatened to **destabilize Western control** over the Middle East and its oil resources. To counter this, within 48 hours of the Baghdad coup the US sent a battalion of marines into Lebanon in **Operation Blue Bat**, to help prop up the tottering regime of President Chamoun. Tensions eased, and the US withdrew its forces on October 25 without a shot being fired.

French wars in Indochina, civil war in Algeria, and a series of unstable governments led to the recall of **General Charles De Gaulle** (see panel, above) to French politics. He demanded special powers for six months to restore order, and to draft a new constitution for a **Fifth Republic**, which was submitted to the French public in a referendum on September 28. De Gaulle won an **easy victory to become president** on December 21, 12 years after he had relinquished power.

Russia's success in launching a satellite in 1957 spurred the Americans into forming **NASA**, the North American Space Agency. On July 29, President Eisenhower signed the **National Aeronautics and Space Act**, and NASA opened formally three months later.

Elvis Presley had become a huge star with a series of chart-topping records, and this year would prove to be pivotal. On January 20, he began work on his fourth motion picture, *King Creole*. Then, at the height of what seemed a promising career, Presley was **conscripted into the army**, and in September he set sail for Germany. Billboard noted a drop in sales of his records and Elvis's army years would mark a clear line between the old Elvis and the new.

